

ETERNAL
ONES



By Kyle Young

The Beginning Of The City Of Roanina

The Deal

On the shoulder of a small green mountain, three ancient siblings watched the world below.

The first was a Fenghuang named Hope. She was a great bird of many colors, her feathers woven from morning light and soft silk. Gold, jade, and crimson shimmered along her wings, and long tail-feathers trailed behind her like ribbons that caught the wind.

Beside her perched a Phoenix called Future. Her feathers were all flame, glowing from deep ember-red at the roots to bright, molten gold at the tips. Smoke curled softly from her wings, and her eyes shone like twin suns just before dawn.

From the bamboo forest below came the third sibling: a Baku named Dream. He was shaped like a great sturdy beast, with the body of a bear, the legs of a tiger, and a long, curling snout made for sniffing out dreams. Patches of his fur were patterned like clouds and night sky, and his eyes held both gentle sleep and sharp nightmares.

Far beneath them lay a village.

It clung to the hillside in neat rows: wooden houses with dark curved roofs, sliding paper doors, narrow stone paths stitched between them like threads. Terraced fields stepped down the mountain—some for rice, some for vegetables—while a little stream wound through it all, crossed by small wooden bridges.

This place did not belong to any land on any map. It lived only in stories and dreams.

Hope sat on the hill, her bright eyes fixed on the village. Down below, men were dragging a heavy deer along the path. Behind them walked a boy with a bow on his back, head hanging low, shoulders tired.

Future tilted her blazing head.

“Hope, what are you staring at?” she asked.

Hope turned her many-colored face toward her sister.

“They just look so sad,” she murmured.

Future followed her gaze. Hunters moved through the village with heavy steps. Smoke rose from cooking fires, but the air felt thick, not joyful.

From the bamboo forest came the sound of rustling. Dream lumbered into view, leaves caught in his star-splattered fur, and began to climb toward them.

“Why do you say they’re sad?” Future asked more quietly.

Hope looked at the tidy little houses, the patched clothes, the children carrying wood instead of playing by the stream.

"Sister," she said, "they spend their days only surviving. I am sure Father made this world for more than 'hunt or be hunted.'"

Dream reached them, his dream-scented breath curling in the air like mist. He settled down in the grass with a soft thump.

"Sisters," he rumbled, "what are you doing all the way up here?"

Future flicked a feather at him.

"Shouldn't you be off eating someone's nightmare?" she teased.

"No one is asleep," Dream replied. "It is day. And you know very well I am lord of both dreams and nightmares."

Future rolled her eyes, sparks flickering from her wings.

"Yes, yes. I see what will be, you see what people wish will be."

She nodded toward the village.

"And that village down there? Its future is not bright."

Dream's ears twitched.

"You always say that," he grumbled. "But unlike you, I can change things. One dream, one wish, one heart—shift that, and the whole path of a life changes."

He lowered his head, eyes gleaming.

"But even I don't think Hope can turn that place into a city full of hope. People down there are too afraid, too tired."

Hope fluffed her feathers.

"I can," she said. "I can change it. I can fill it with people of hope."

Dream snorted.

"I don't think you can," he said. "The future is already bent. That city—that future—is not yours to fix."

Future watched them both, a slow smile spreading across her fiery face.

"Then let's make a game," she said. "Look down."

All three of them gazed at the village again. For a moment, it seemed to stretch and blur. Hope could see faint images laid over it: roads that didn't exist yet, taller houses, strange moving carts, lights brighter than any lamp. The days ahead unfolded below them like a long painted scroll.

"The future," Future said softly, "will be our game board."

Hope and Dream listened.

“Hope,” Future went on, “you will try to guide this village into something better—into a city filled with hopeful people. Dream thinks you cannot. You think you can. So we’ll play.”

Hope tilted her head.

“What are the rules?” she asked.

Dream’s mouth curled into a grin.

“Make them hard,” he said.

Future laughed.

“Of course. This is how it will work:

Every ten years, one pure heart from this place may make a wish. Hope will listen and carry that wish. Dream will shape it in the realm of dreams. And I—” her eyes glowed brighter—“I will lay the wish onto the board of time and see where it leads.”

She reached out her hand to Hope.

“Use time as your guide,” she said.

Dream stepped closer, his heavy paw resting gently over both their hands.

“Use Dream to make the wish true,” he added.

Hope looked from one sibling to the other. There was teasing in their eyes, and challenge—but also love.

“And I,” she said, placing a wing over their joined hands, “will use Hope as my strength.”

Dream pulled back slightly.

“I still say you won’t manage it,” he muttered. “You’ll help them, yes. You’ll heal some hearts. But a whole city filled with hope? No.”

Hope gave him a small, stubborn smile.

“Then that is what I will prove you wrong about, big brother.”

Future chuckled.

“Sister against brother, with me in the middle as referee,” she said. “Perfect.”

Dream’s starry eyes softened.

“If you fail,” he said gently, “we will still be here.”

“And if I win,” Hope replied, “you’ll both admit I was right.”

Future rolled her eyes again.

“We shall see,” she said. “For now, the game begins.”

Flame rose around Future like a cloak, and mist and starlight curled around Dream. For a heartbeat they were bird and beast, and then they shimmered into human shapes: a tall woman with fire-bright eyes, and a broad-shouldered man whose hair looked like night sky.

They squeezed Hope's winged shoulder—one on each side, like the siblings they were—and then, with a blink, they vanished from the mountaintop, leaving her alone with the wind.

Hope looked down at the village, at the first little square on the great game board of the future. A small smile touched her beak.

"Then it's time to play," she whispered. "Time to deal out hope."

With a sweep of her bright wings, the Fenghuang soared down toward the houses. Roof tiles flashed beneath her; lanterns swayed as she passed. She glided over the narrow streets, searching for someone whose heart was ready for a wish.

She closed her eyes and let her power feel its way through the village: through tired voices, clinking tools, soft sighs, and small, hidden dreams.

At last, she felt it—the thinnest, hungriest dream of all.

Hope folded her wings and dropped gently toward a small tent at the edge of the fields. Inside, a boy sat alone, his bow beside him, his hands resting on his knees. When he saw the many-colored bird, he gasped and stumbled back.

"I'm sorry," Hope said quickly. "I didn't mean to frighten you. I'm here to help."

"How can a bird talk?" he whispered. "And... how can you help?"

"I am one of the Eternal Ones," Hope said. "Every ten years I will stand on that mountain top and listen for a brave heart with a wish. Today, that heart is yours. So tell me—what do you wish for?"

The boy looked at his scratched hands and thought of cold mornings and empty bellies.

"I wish..." His voice shook. "I wish I didn't have to hunt for food every day. I wish no one in this village had to."

Hope's eyes softened.

"A wish for everyone," she said. "That is a fine wish."

Her feathers grew brighter.

"Your wish," she told him, "is the first move on our board."

She leapt into the sky and began to circle an empty patch of earth by the stream. Golden feathers fell from her wings, turning into light as they touched the ground. Slowly, a building rose from nothing: shelves of food that never emptied, baskets that never ran out.

Far off, Dream watched from the shadows of the bamboo forest, tail flicking. Future watched from somewhere beyond the clouds, counting the years already sliding into place.

And Hope, the youngest, flew back toward her mountain, ready to return again in ten years—again and again—as long as there was even one small heart brave enough to wish, and one more move to make on the board of the future.

10 Years Later

On the highest peak above the village, where the wind braided itself through the grass, the Fenghuang waited with the sun at her back. Her feathers shimmered like dawn, and the light made her look almost too bright to gaze upon.

Up the narrow stone path climbed a man, no longer the frightened boy from long ago. Behind him followed the people of the village, walking slowly, their eyes full of wonder and memory.

"I told you the bird would be here," the man said over his shoulder.

When he reached the top, Hope, the Fenghuang, tilted her head and smiled with her bright, jeweled eyes.

"It is nice to see you again," she said.

The young man smiled back, a little shy despite the many watching.

"It is nice to see you as well," he answered. "What is your name, truly? I've searched and searched, but I can't find anything written about the Eternal Ones."

Hope gave a soft, musical laugh.

"That is because my brothers and sisters hide themselves in legends," she said. "We are whispered in stories, painted in dreams. Each of us stands for something different. One of my brothers rules over dreams and nightmares—and the dreams of hope as well. One of my sisters sees the future in one eye and the past in the other."

The young man sat down beside her, careful and respectful, as if the grass itself were holy.

"Then... are you Wishes and Curses?" he asked.

Hope laughed again, the sound like bells in the breeze.

"That would make sense," she admitted. "But no. I am Hope and Despair, both together. I carry the weight of what is lost, and the light of what may yet be found. I am here to bring hope to everyone who lives below."

The young man nodded slowly.

"My name is Thorne," he said at last.

The Fenghuang bowed her graceful head.

"It is an honor to meet you, Thorne. Tell me—what is your wish?"

Thorne looked down at the village spread out beneath them: the wooden houses rebuilt, the fields green again, the stream winding like a silver ribbon. His voice grew quieter as he spoke.

"I have thought about this for a long time," he said. "After the first wish, when you gave us food that never runs out... we were happy. But then the great tornado came. It tore our homes apart and took half our people. We rebuilt. We always rebuild. But if every step forward is followed by two steps back, we will never truly move ahead."

He drew a breath, his hands curling into the grass.

“So I wish this: that no natural disaster ever strikes my village again.”

Hope studied him for a moment, and in her eyes shone the memory of storms and the promise of calm.

“A noble wish,” she said softly.

Below them, the village seemed to brighten as the sun poured its light over rooftops and fields. For a heartbeat, everything glowed as if wrapped in a gentle blessing.

The Fenghuang bowed low to Thorne. Her feathers began to shimmer and fade at the edges, like mist drifting away in morning light.

“Thank you,” Thorne said, rising to his feet, his eyes shining not just with relief, but with a quiet, steady courage.

Hope gave him one last, warm look as she vanished into the sunlight.

Then Thorne turned and walked back down the mountain toward his people, carrying with him the unshakable knowledge that, at last, the ground beneath their feet would hold firm—and that somewhere, in the hidden places between stories and sky, Hope still watched over them.

20 Years Later

Rain clouds wrapped themselves around the mountain like a gray cloak, and the sky was full of soft, steady drizzle. High above the village, on the familiar mountain top, the Fenghuang lay resting with her jewel-bright feathers tucked close against the chill.

Once more, footsteps began to climb the stone stairs that wound up the mountainside. Slowly, carefully, a man came into view—older now, but still with the same steady eyes. It was Thorne, the boy who had once wished food for all his people.

This time, he was not alone.

At his side walked a young woman with kind eyes and rain-damp hair, her cloak beaded with silver drops. Together they reached the top, and Thorne lifted his hand in greeting.

“Hello, Hope,” he said softly.

Hope rose and bowed her graceful head, her feathers gleaming faintly even under the dim, clouded light. Thorne helped the woman sit down upon a smooth rock, then settled beside her.

“This is Faye,” he said, pride and warmth in his voice.

The Fenghuang turned her bright gaze to the woman.

“It is very nice to meet you, Faye,” she said. “My name is Hope.”

Faye smiled, a little shy but unafraid.

“It is nice to meet you,” she answered. She glanced at Thorne, then back at the great bird.

“You are as beautiful as he described.”

Hope’s eyes softened, and she dipped her head again.

“Thank you,” she replied. Then she turned to Thorne, her expression growing gently serious.

“Tell me, Thorne—what is your wish this time?”

Thorne looked at his wife, then down at his hands. The rain tapped softly on stone and feather and cloth.

“Well,” he began, “I look at my wife, and we are thinking about having a child. But one of my dearest friends... his wife died in childbirth. I do not want that sorrow to fall on anyone ever again.”

His voice tightened, but he continued.

“So my wish is this: in my village, may no one ever die giving birth to a child.”

Hope turned her gaze from Thorne to Faye, and then out over the village hidden beneath the gray curtain of rain.

“A true wish,” she said at last, her voice quiet but strong. “No one should have to say goodbye at the very moment they say hello to their child.”

She spread her wings.

The air around her shimmered. Soft, green light began to glow along her feathers, like new leaves after a storm. With each slow, powerful beat of her wings, that light flowed outward, drifting down the mountain like mist.

It slipped through rooftops and walls, across fields and paths, in and out of every home. It settled over the women of the village—over mothers, daughters, grandmothers, and those who had not yet even thought of children. It wrapped them in a gentle, unseen blessing, as soft as a lullaby yet strong as stone.

Thorne and Faye watched in awed silence.

The last threads of green light faded into the rain-soaked sky. Hope looked at them one final time, her eyes full of quiet promise.

Then, little by little, the Fenghuang began to fade—first her tail, then her wings, then her shining eyes—until she was gone, leaving only the soft whisper of feathers in the wind and the memory of her blessing upon the mountain top.

30 Years Later

The day was quiet on the stone terrace halfway up the mountain, where the village elders sometimes went to think. Moss grew between the cracks, and the wind carried the faint smell of pine and cooking fires from below.

From the sky, a shimmer of color descended.

Hope, the Fenghuang, glided down in a sweep of golden and crimson feathers and landed lightly upon the stones. Her long tail trailed behind her like painted ribbons, and her bright eyes searched the terrace.

There, sitting alone on a flat stone, was a small boy.

She tilted her head.

“What is your name?” she asked gently.

The boy looked up at the great, shining bird and stood, dusting off his clothes.

“My name is Maroku,” he said.

Maroku lifted his hand, and Hope bowed her head toward him. Carefully, he reached out and began to pat her feathers, his small fingers sinking into the soft, warm plumage. He laughed quietly to himself, comforted by her presence.

Footsteps sounded on the stone path.

Faye and Thorne were climbing toward them. Thorne’s steps were slow and uneven, and a harsh cough shook his body as they climbed. Faye kept one hand pressed to his back, rubbing in small circles, steadying him until at last they reached the terrace.

Thorne sank down onto the stone, breathing hard. Faye scooped Maroku into her arms and sat beside him, holding the boy close.

“I’m so sorry,” Faye said quickly, looking at Hope with worried eyes. “I’ve told Maroku not to pat you without asking.”

Hope only shook her head slightly, her feathers whispering. Before she could reply, Thorne doubled over with another cough—this time, dark drops of blood spattered the stone at his feet.

Hope’s eyes widened.

“Are you all right?” she asked.

Faye’s face tightened with helpless sorrow.

“No,” she said quietly. “He fell ill a few years ago, and... he hasn’t gotten any better.”

Thorne wiped his mouth and lifted his gaze to the Fenghuang.

“If I die,” he asked, voice rough, “will you still keep coming back?”

Hope's brightness dimmed, and a sadness settled into her eyes.

"Yes," she answered softly. "I will."

Thorne looked at Faye, at Maroku, and then back to Hope.

"Then... if I'm gone," he said, "will the wish go to Maroku or to my wife?"

Hope's sorrow shifted into a small, gentle smile.

"The wish was never truly yours alone," she said. "It came to you because your heart was pure. So long as your family keeps such a heart, the wish will belong to them as well."

Thorne and Faye looked at one another. In that long, quiet glance, they seemed to speak without words—fear, love, worry, and hope all passing between them.

At last, Thorne turned back to Hope. He pushed himself to his feet, though his legs shook beneath him.

"I wish," he began firmly, "that my village will be protected from outside attack."

Before Hope could spread her wings or speak a single word of power, Faye's hand closed around Thorne's shoulder.

"What are you doing?" she cried, her voice breaking. "We talked about this."

Her eyes shone with unshed tears.

Thorne turned to her, his expression grave.

"I have heard news from beyond the mountains," he said. "Soldiers are coming—for our endless food, for what we were given. If we do nothing, they will bring war to our door. We must hide ourselves. We must prevent the battle before it begins. This wish... this is the answer."

Faye cupped his face in both hands, forcing him to look at her.

"No," she whispered. "You have to save yourself. Our people need a leader. They need someone to guide them. We can live through storms and hardship. We have before. But we cannot lose you."

Thorne searched her eyes, his voice softening.

"That is what I am trying to do," he said. "Save you. Save Maroku. Save them all—by hiding everyone, everything."

They both turned then to Hope, who stood silent and watchful.

"You're the one who grants the wishes," Faye said. "Which wish do you think is more important?"

The Fenghuang lowered her head, considering. The wind tugged at her feathers, and for a moment the only sound was Thorne's quiet, strained breathing and Maroku's small, anxious fidgeting in his mother's lap.

"A village can outlive an attack," Hope said at last, her voice low. "Houses can be rebuilt. Fields can be planted again. Wounds can heal. But a village cannot survive a slow destruction from within. To outlive that kind of ruin, people need a leader to believe in—a leader they can trust."

She lifted her gaze to Thorne, her eyes bright and unblinking.

"Do you believe you can pass your role to someone you truly trust?" she asked. "Or do you believe your people are not yet ready to say goodbye to you?"

Thorne stood there, rain clouds gathering overhead, the first drops beginning to fall. Water splashed on stone, on feather, on skin. Faye held Maroku close, and Hope waited, still as a statue of living light.

Thorne lowered his eyes to the wet stones at his feet. The rain fell harder, washing away the spots of blood, trailing like silver threads down his cheeks.

He drew a breath.

"I wish..." he began.

The Beginning Of A New Era

40 Years Later

The sky above the mountain was heavy and gray, and the air was very still.

Hope, the Fenghuang, glided down toward the stone terrace where she had so often met Thorne and his family. But as she drew nearer, her bright eyes widened.

The stones were stained with dried blood.

Her heart clenched. She beat her wings and flew down the mountain path, faster and faster. Along the way, she saw broken pieces of armor scattered in the dirt, swords half-buried in the earth, shattered shields, and torn flags. The path that had once carried peaceful footsteps was now lined with the remains of battle.

Horror filled her as she followed the trail.

At last, she reached a clearing where bodies lay still as fallen leaves. Among them, a figure moved.

Maroku—no longer a child, but a young man—stood among the fallen. His clothes were spattered with dirt and blood. A sword hung in his hand, its blade dull with use.

Hope swooped down and landed before him.

He turned to her, eyes tired and sharp.

“So,” he said, his voice dry and bitter, “is it that time again? You’re back. Last time you came, you ruined everything.”

Hope looked around at the broken armor, the silent men, the stained earth. All she could feel around her was despair.

She stepped closer, her talons clicking lightly on the stone.

“What do you mean?” she asked softly. “The wish should have stopped this.”

Maroku gave a short, humorless laugh.

“You’d think so, wouldn’t you?” he said. “But it turns out... it doesn’t matter.”

He thrust the sword into the ground and dropped down to sit beside it, shoulders bowed. He lifted his face to her, his eyes full of anger and hurt.

“Why didn’t you listen to your own advice?” he asked.

Hope was silent for a moment. Then her form began to glow.

Feathers melted into light, and light folded into shape. Where the bird had stood, there now knelt a woman. She had silk-red hair that fell like a river over her shoulders. Her dress was split in two: one half black as midnight, covered in shining tear-shaped drops that seemed to be forever falling; the other half bright and simple, like the clothes of a cheerful farm girl from a festival story—full of color, warmth, and life.

Hope bent down so that she could look Maroku in the eyes.

"I only did what your father asked of me," she said gently.

Maroku stared at her, stunned.

"He never told me you could turn into a woman," he breathed.

Hope smiled, a little sadly.

"That is because he never knew," she said. "To him, a magical bird from far away was easier to understand. But I saw your eyes long ago, when you were small, and I see them now. For you, this form—a woman split between light and darkness—is easier to face."

Maroku slowly pushed himself to his feet.

"So you're telling me," he said, "that I have the next wish?"

Hope's smile grew a bit warmer.

"Yes," she said. "This time, I would choose carefully... and make it a good one."

She straightened and looked around them: the bodies, the scattered steel, the quiet, wounded earth.

"Your father's wish was meant to prevent this," she murmured. "A wish to hide your village from outside attacks."

Maroku's lips curled into a sad, crooked smile.

"You're right," he said. "And it did work. The danger from outside was kept away for a time. But when Father died, there was no trusted leader to gather the pieces and hold us together. Mother—Faye—died only a few days later. Some of the people believed in me... others did not."

Hope turned back to him. A few tears slipped down his cheeks, cutting clean tracks through the dust on his face.

"I don't know how to be the leader they need, with my men kill off the last of the other group and the woman and children hidden underground with some wanting the other side to win," he confessed. "I've seen the anger in their eyes, the fear, the doubt. So I wish..." He drew a breath, voice trembling. "I wish I could be the leader they need. The leader who can guide my village into a new era—with hope and with faith."

Hope studied him quietly.

“That wish may change you completely,” she warned. “It may reshape your heart and mind. It may break apart the person you are now and build something new in your place.”

Maroku met her gaze and—despite everything—smiled.

“I lost who I was when my mother died,” he said softly. “If I can become someone who will save them... then let it change me.”

Hope lifted her hand and laid her palm gently against Maroku’s cheek. Her touch was warm, like the first sunlight after a storm.

“As you wished,” she whispered.

Magic began to flow from her hand, swirling like silver mist and golden fire. It poured into him—into his heart, into his bones, into the spaces where grief and doubt had lived too long.

The battlefield remained silent, but something in the air shifted, as if the future itself were holding its breath.

50 Years Later

The Fenghuang soared high above the familiar mountain, her wings catching the morning light. As Hope circled lower, she realized the world below had changed.

The little village was gone.

In its place stood a bustling small town. Wooden buildings rose in tidy rows, their roofs dark and shining after recent rain. Lanterns hung from carved beams, and narrow streets crisscrossed like threads in a beautiful tapestry. At the very heart of it all stood a great temple, tall and graceful, its wide steps and curving roof watching over everything like a guardian.

Hope glided down, feathers glimmering, and landed upon the flagstones before the temple.

There, walking quickly through the courtyard, was Maroku. He was no longer the uncertain boy she had met among fallen swords, but a young man in fine robes, his face lined with care. His brow was furrowed, as if he were carrying the whole town on his shoulders.

Hope shimmered, feathers melting into light, and became the woman once more—silk-red hair falling down her back, her dress still split in two: one half dark and weeping with tiny tear-shaped jewels, the other bright and simple like a cheerful farm girl's clothes.

"So," she said with a small smile, "you've been busy, then."

Maroku turned. For a moment, the worry on his face disappeared. He broke into a wide smile and hurried to her. Without thinking, he swept her up in his arms and spun her around, laughing—a sound full of the boy he had once been.

"Yeah," he said, breathless and happy, "I have been."

He set her down gently, then took her hand in his.

"Come," he said.

He led her out of the temple courtyard and into the town itself. Hope let herself be pulled along, her eyes wide. From above, she had seen roofs and streets. From the ground, she saw people.

Women laughing together by a well. Children chasing one another through the alleys. Merchants calling out their wares in front of wooden stalls. Smoke curling from chimney tops where meals were being cooked. The world she had helped shape was alive and breathing all around her.

Maroku stopped and stepped back, watching her face instead of the town.

"It looks different from down here, doesn't it?" he asked softly.

Hope turned to him, a gentle wonder in her eyes.

"It does," she replied.

Maroku's gaze flicked over her dress—half sorrow, half joy—and then back to her face.

"Do you think..." he began, hesitating for the first time, "do you think you can stay for a few hours?"

Hope blinked, surprised. Wishes were usually quick things: asked, granted, and then she would slip away like morning mist. The idea of simply staying was almost strange.

"I usually come and go," she said slowly.

Maroku stepped a little closer, eyes shining.

"I know," he said. "But this world—you're changing it. You're shaping it with every wish. Don't you want to experience it? Don't you want to live in it, even just for a little while?"

Hope looked around once more—the wooden houses, the market stalls, the distant sound of temple bells, the people whose lives had been touched by her power. Then she looked back at Maroku, at the hope and trust in his gaze.

"I think..." she said at last, a smile curving her lips, "I will."

Maroku's face lit up. He squeezed her hand and, laughing, pulled her into a run.

Together they ran through the streets of the wooden town—past shopkeepers and children, under swaying lanterns and between busy doorways. For the first time in a very long time, Hope was not just a distant guardian, not just a great bird upon a mountain.

For a little while, in the town that had grown from wishes and courage, she lived among the people whose stories she had helped to write.

Evening settled gently over the wooden town. Lanterns glowed like tiny moons along the streets, and from the great house near the temple, warm light spilled out into the night.

Inside, Hope sat at a long dining table, in her human form with silk-red hair and a dress half-shadow, half-sunlight. Across from her sat Maroku, the young leader of the town she had watched grow from a frightened village.

Between them steam curled from bowls of fragrant soup, plates of roasted vegetables, and sweet cakes dusted with sugar. Laughter and distant music drifted through the open window.

Hope glanced outside. The sky was dark and clear, crowded with stars. Then she turned back to Maroku, her eyes shining in the lamplight.

"So," she said softly, "you must tell me—what is your wish?"

Maroku smiled, setting down his chopsticks.
“You’ve asked me that many times tonight,” he said.

Hope reached across the table and took his hand in both of hers. Her touch was warm and light.

“That is because I need to know,” she answered. “It is what I am here for.”

Maroku’s smile deepened, though there was something searching in his gaze.
“I’ll tell you,” he said, “but only if you promise not to leave the moment I speak the words.”

Hope’s lips curved into a small, secret smile.
“Very well,” she said. “I won’t leave. Not this time.”

Maroku leaned back in his chair, his face lighting up like a boy’s for a moment.

“My town is growing,” he began. “Every day, there are new houses, new ideas. But as we grow, we need more—supplies, tools, materials stronger than wood and stone. Things no one has ever seen before, so we can keep building and inventing. Can you help with that?”

Hope tilted her head, amused.

“I can,” she said. “But only if you say the words.”

Maroku drew a breath, then spoke clearly:

“I wish there were rare materials in the ground beneath this town—metals and stones that could be mined and used to push our knowledge and craft forward, to help my people build wonders.”

Hope smiled and closed her eyes.

Soft magic began to shimmer around her like dust caught in sunlight. It drifted through the floorboards, down into the earth—spreading into the deep dark places beneath the town, where seeds of strange ores and gleaming crystals began to form.

When the glow faded, Hope opened her eyes and grinned.

“There,” she said lightly. “All done. Just like that. Now...” She picked up a small paper menu, turning it thoughtfully. “I want to try something else from this list.”

Maroku chuckled and went back to his food, watching her with fondness.

After a moment he asked,
“So why today? Of all the days in ten years, why did you choose this one to stay so long?”

Hope put the menu down, tracing its edge with her finger.

"No special reason," she said, though her voice had a hint of carefulness. "It was simply the first day the very first wish was made. I return when the circle completes."

Maroku's expression shifted. He looked at her as though seeing her in a new light.

"So you're telling me," he said slowly, "that you could make a wish come true any time you wanted... if you chose to?"

Hope shook her head, smiling sadly.

"No," she replied. "It doesn't work like that."

Before she could say more, Maroku reached for her hand again, holding it firmly.

Hope flinched, startled by the feeling that sparked at his touch, and rose quickly from her chair, the legs scraping softly against the floor.

"No," she said, stepping back, her voice trembling in a way that had nothing to do with fear of battles or storms. "This—us—cannot happen."

Maroku stood as well, confusion and hurt flickering across his face.

"What do you mean?" he asked.

Hope only shook her head, unable to meet his eyes. The shadows and colors of her dress rippled like water, and her form began to glow.

In a breath, the woman was gone.

Feathers burst where she had stood, and the great Fenghuang took shape—wings wide, tail streaming behind her like a banner of night and dawn. With a single powerful beat, she flew out the open window into the starry sky, leaving the warm room, the half-eaten meal, and Maroku standing alone in the lantern light.

Outside, the town she had helped to build glittered below her. But that night, for the first time, Hope fled not from danger or war...

...but from her own heart.

Hope, in her true form as the Fenghuang, flew through the shining tear in the sky.

She passed through one glowing portal, then another, then a third—each one a ring of light humming softly as she slipped through it—until the world around her changed. The mountains and forests were gone. Beneath her stretched only endless water, dark and deep, gently rising and falling like the breath of some great sleeping beast.

In the middle of that vast sea stood a single black rock, worn smooth by the waves.

On that rock stood a Unicorn.

Her mane flowed like silver water, her horn shimmered with soft light, and her hooves rested lightly on the stone as the ocean swirled around her. She gazed out at the horizon, watching the waves roll and break in their slow, endless dance.

Hope glided down and landed beside her, feathers rustling.

“Love,” Hope said, tilting her golden head, “this is a strange place to spend your time.”

The Unicorn turned and smiled, her eyes warm and knowing.

“Sister,” she said, her voice as gentle as moonlight on the sea, “it is nice to see you as well.”

She folded her legs and lay down gracefully upon the rock, the water spraying around them in a soft mist. Hope settled beside her, tucking her wings.

“You are the expert in matters of love,” Hope began quietly. “Tell me... what happens if an Eternal One falls in love with a human?”

The Unicorn’s smile grew a little wider, a little more mischievous.

“Well,” she said, “I do not know if you are asking for a some else or for yourself... but I can tell you this.”

She dipped her horn toward the sea, and the waves seemed to listen.

“If an Eternal One falls in love with a human, a choice must be made. Either the Eternal gives up their endless nature and becomes human... or they must convince all our brothers and sisters that the one they love is worthy to become Eternal.”

Hope watched the sea, her feathers stirring in the salty wind.

The Unicorn went on, her gaze fixed on the horizon.

“Look around you, Hope. Love is like the ocean. Sometimes the sea is calm, and you hardly feel it at all. Other times, the waves rise wild and high, and everything is chaos, and you feel love take hold of you so strongly you can hardly breathe.”

A wave crashed against the rock, sending up a spray that glittered around them like stars.

“Love is not just one moment, one grand gesture,” the Unicorn said softly. “It is a series of actions. It is waking up each day and choosing to walk together toward the same goal.”

She turned her shining eyes to Hope.

“But if I were you, little sister, I would wait and watch. See whether his actions are truly love... or only manipulation.”

With that, the Unicorn rose elegantly to her hooves. She took one step, then another, to the very edge of the rock.

Without hesitation, she leapt.

Her silver body arced through the air, and she dove into the sea, disappearing beneath the dark, rolling waves. Rings of light spread across the water where she had vanished.

Hope remained on the rock, the wind ruffling her bright feathers. She watched the ocean move—calm and restless, gentle and fierce—all at once.

And as she watched, she thought of a town of wood and lanterns, of a young man with tired eyes and a hopeful heart, and of the choice that now waited for her, as endless and uncertain as the sea.

60 Years Later

Twilight lay soft upon the mountain, painting the sky in shades of rose and violet. The wind was gentle, carrying up the distant sounds of hammers, carts, and voices from the growing town below.

On the mountaintop, carved into the rock, stood a new stone seat. Upon it sat Maroku, now a man in his late twenties, shoulders broad with responsibility and eyes older than his years. He leaned back, watching the world he was helping to shape.

From above came the whisper of great wings.

Hope, the Fenghuang, descended from the clouds in a shimmer of crimson and gold. She landed lightly before him, her feathers glowing in the fading light. For a moment, she simply looked at him.

Then feathers became light, and light became flesh.

Once more she stood as a woman: silk-red hair falling down her back, her dress split in two. But this time, the side of darkness had grown, taking up more than half the fabric, dripping with jeweled tears. The bright, farm-girl side seemed smaller, though it still shone.

For a heartbeat, neither of them spoke.

“How are you?” Hope asked at last, her voice soft.

Maroku gave a half-smile.

“I’m well,” he said. “And how are you—considering that the last time I saw you, you ran from our dinner as fast as you could?”

A faint blush rose in Hope’s cheeks, and she smiled awkwardly.

“I am sorry about that,” she said. “I had a calling. Being Hope and Despair for an entire universe is... difficult. Something urgent arose.”

Maroku sat up straighter, studying her.

“So,” he said quietly, “loving you is like loving the stars, then.”

Hope blinked, taken aback.

“You don’t know what those words mean,” she protested, flustered.

“Maybe not,” Maroku replied, his smile turning softer, more serious. “But from where I’m sitting, I know this: I am willing to wait. To have one conversation with you every ten years... until my last.”

Something in Hope’s posture changed. She looked suddenly unsure, as if the ground had shifted beneath her feet.

“Well,” she said slowly, “I could stay as long as I am able. But first, I must know your wish.”

Maroku glanced over his shoulder.

Below them, the wooden town had grown into something larger—almost a city now. Buildings climbed the slopes, streets spread like a web, and lanterns winked to life as night approached. Carts rattled along the roads, carrying goods from the mines.

“At this point,” he said, turning back to her, “we have mines full of gold and rare materials, but moving them through the town is slow and difficult. So my wish is this: give me designs, a way to move these materials quickly and safely to everyone who needs them.”

Hope smiled and raised her hand.

With a small snap of her fingers, a flurry of papers appeared in Maroku’s lap—covered in neat lines and symbols: plans for tracks and carts, pulleys and lifts, ways to join the town together with paths of iron and wood.

“There,” she said. “The wish is granted.”

She folded her hands and tilted her head.

“So,” she added lightly, “what do you want to talk about?”

Maroku looked at the papers, then back at her.

“Why this village?” he asked. “Out of all the places in our universe... why us?”

Hope’s smile returned, but it was thin and playful in a way that did not quite reach her eyes.

“Why not?” she answered.

Maroku’s gaze sharpened. He could tell she was hiding something, but he let it pass—for the moment.

“Then what is the goal?” he asked softly. “All of these wishes, all of this shaping... What are you truly trying to do?”

Hope leaned a little closer, the bright side of her dress catching what was left of the light.

“I am Hope and Despair,” she said. “I am tired of watching sadness cover the worlds like fog. I want to feel hope—for everyone in this town. I want to see them stand, thrive, and shine.”

Maroku studied her face.

“Are you certain,” he asked quietly, “that is the real reason you’re doing all this?”

Hope frowned, confused.

“What do you mean?”

Maroku looked out over the growing city, then back at her, his eyes gentle but unflinching.

“To me,” he said, “it feels as though you picked a random village to play a long, difficult game of fate. You say you’re trying to bring hope to us... but it sounds like you’re trying to find hope for yourself. Knowing you must come back here every ten years—doesn’t that give *you* a reason to carry on? A reason to keep going, even when the universe feels too heavy?”

His words struck her like a sudden wind.

Hope stood abruptly, as if the stone beneath her had become too hot to bear. She hadn't realized how deeply his truth might cut until it did.

"I will see you in another ten years," she said quickly, her voice tight.

She turned away, her form already beginning to glow.

"Wait," Maroku said, rising to his feet. Regret flashed across his face. "Hope—I'm sorry. I didn't mean—"

But feathers were already spilling from the light. Hope became the Fenghuang once more, wings spreading wide, darkness and color rippling along her plumage.

Without looking back, she leapt into the waiting portal of shimmering air that had opened above the mountain peak.

Maroku lunged forward, hand outstretched.

"No—Hope, I'm sorry!" he cried.

But his fingers closed on empty air. The portal swallowed the light of her wings and sealed itself with a soft sigh, leaving only the night wind and the distant lanterns of the city below, and Maroku standing alone beneath the stars he had once said he was willing to love.

70 Years Later

Maroku climbed the stone steps of the mountain once more.

The wind at that height carried the scent of pine and distant rain, and below him the city he had built glowed with lantern light, its streets winding like golden rivers through the dark.

At the very top, on the familiar flat of stone, someone was already waiting.

Hope sat there in her human form: silk-red hair loose about her shoulders, dress still split between light and shadow. The dark half seemed deeper than before, heavy with tear-shaped jewels; the bright half still shone with quiet warmth.

"I thought I would be early this time," she said with a small smile.

Maroku smiled back and went to sit on the stone seat beside her.

"You look amazing, as always," he said. "Do the Eternal Ones never age?"

Hope's smile softened.

"Well," she replied, "it is rather in the name. Eternal means forever—without end." She paused, then tilted her head. "May I ask you something?"

Maroku laughed lightly.

"What could you possibly want to know about me? You've been watching my life play out in front of your eyes."

Hope's eyes grew thoughtful.

"You and your father both had the chance to make selfish wishes," she said. "You could have asked for power—strength, magic, anything for yourself."

Maroku looked out over the city below, then back at her.

"I never really thought about it," he admitted. "I've spent my life trying to build a city people will remember—a place where they feel safe, where they can build a life without fear."

Hope studied his face and nodded.

"I can see you're telling the truth," she said. "That is why you and your father both had pure hearts." She hesitated, then added, "But you should find someone. Someone you can pass this city on to."

Maroku's lips curved into a gentle smile.

"I already have," he said. "I'm looking right at them."

Hope's expression changed, turning sad and sharp all at once.

“Trust me,” she replied quietly, “that is not an option. You are like a dear pet to me—precious, but fleeting. You will die, and I will go on living, carrying the weight of your loss. I will have to keep walking when you have turned to dust.”

Maroku did not look away. His smile did not falter, though it grew more tender.

“But like dust,” he said softly, “I will still float around you, carried by every wind. I’ll be smiling—because I had the chance to know you, even for a moment.”

Hope stood, her eyes clouded with something he could not name.

“You are a young man,” she said. “You still cannot see the whole picture. So—what is your wish?”

Maroku rose to his feet as well. He stood facing her, small beneath the vast sky, yet unafraid.

“You’re right,” he said. “I am young, compared to you.” He drew a breath. “So I wish... to be as Eternal as you.”

Hope’s smile returned, but it was full of both fondness and sorrow.

“It doesn’t work like that,” she said. “You cannot simply wish to become one of us.”

Maroku took a step closer. Now they stood so near he could feel her breath, and she could feel his.

“Why not?” he asked quietly.

Hope searched his eyes for a long moment. Then she sighed, as though laying down a burden she had carried for centuries.

“I can make you Eternal,” she said at last, “but only on one condition: you must remain here. In this place. You will belong to this mountain and this city. Your eternity will be bound to them.”

Maroku glanced once more at the glowing city below—the people walking its streets, the homes filled with light, the temple standing tall at its heart. When he looked back at Hope, his answer was simple.

“That sounds perfect to me,” he said.

Hope lifted her hand and laid it gently against his cheek. Her touch was warm, and for the first time it trembled, just a little.

She leaned in and pressed a kiss to his other cheek.

Magic flowed from her like water, like light, like all the wishes she had ever granted woven into one. It poured into him, filling his heart, his bones, the threads of his life, tying him to the mountain, the city, the people.

Maroku closed his eyes, letting the warmth wash through him.

When he opened them, her hand was gone.

The mountaintop was silent. The air still shimmered faintly where she had stood, as if a great bird had just taken flight, but Hope herself was nowhere to be seen.

He stood there alone beneath the sky—no longer just a man with a mortal span, but something halfway between earth and eternity—bound to the city he loved, and to the memory of the Eternal who had vanished into the unseen spaces between stars.

The Beginning Of A New Etenral

80 Years Later

Maroku climbed the mountain path, the wind soft against his face. At the top, he saw Hope standing there as a young woman. Her dress looked simple, like a farm girl's dress, but it was covered in flowers.

As he watched, the flowers on her dress began to move. They opened and closed, blooming and changing color in the gentle breeze. At first, Hope smiled at him—but slowly, that smile began to fade. Her eyes filled with sadness.

Maroku felt his heart tighten.
“Hope... what’s wrong?” he asked.

Hope lowered her head.
“Your heart is pure no more,” she whispered.

Maroku frowned.
“I have killed people,” he said quietly. “I have done bad things before. Why would my heart change now?”

Hope looked up at him, her eyes shining with sorrow and kindness.
“Your intention changed,” she said. “Before, you believed you were fighting for your people. You believed you were doing what was right. But now, in your heart, you did something not for your people, not for the good of the world... but for yourself.”

Maroku turned and looked down at the city below. Trains puffed clouds of smoke as they moved cargo from place to place. Buildings were rising, and the air was growing thick and gray.

He stared at the ground and spoke softly.
“It was my last wish,” he said. “A part of me wanted to live to guide my people... but another part wanted to live just to see you again.”

Then he turned back to Hope.

“Go and find them,” he said gently. “I will still be here.”

Hope’s sadness softened. She smiled and bowed. In a burst of light, she changed into a Fenghuang—a great, shining phoenix with bright, blazing feathers. She spread her wings and flew down toward the city.

She soared between the growing buildings, through air heavy with smoke. Below her, people hurried along the streets. As she watched, she saw a child running away from home, tiny footsteps pounding against the stone roads.

Hope followed the child through the city until the child stopped by a river at the very edge of the buildings.

There, Hope landed and changed shape again. Now she was a small girl. She wore pants that looked like black raindrops and a shirt made of living flowers. Both her pants and shirt moved and shifted, as if they were alive. Over them she wore a half-and-half jacket, one side dark, the other bright.

She walked over calmly and sat down beside the child.

“How are you?” Hope asked softly.

The child turned to her. It was a girl with tear-filled eyes.

“I’m okay,” she said shakily. “My name is Lyria. What’s yours?”

Hope smiled kindly.

“My name is Hope. It’s very nice to meet you. I saw you running. Is something wrong?”

Lyria tried to hide the hurt in her eyes. She forced a small smile.

“Nothing,” she said. “I’ve lived through worse before.”

Hope looked out at the river, the city reflected in the water.

“Do you know where the best view of the city is?” she asked.

Lyria blinked and then shook her head.

“No.”

“Come on,” Hope said, standing up. She gently took Lyria’s hand and led her up the hill.

Together they climbed until the whole city stretched out before them like a painting—trains, smoke, buildings, and tiny people moving about their lives.

At the top of the hill stood Maroku.

Hope smiled and turned to Lyria.

“Lyria, this is Maroku,” she said. “He is one of my friends.”

Lyria looked up at him in surprise. She bowed quickly.

“Oh! Great one, I didn’t know you were there.”

Maroku glanced at Hope.

“Is she the next one?” he asked quietly.

Hope smiled and nodded.

Maroku turned back to Lyria and said, “Don’t worry about it.”

Lyria frowned and stood up straighter.

“What’s going on?” she asked.

Maroku smiled gently.

“Every ten years, I was given the power to make a wish,” he explained. “But now, that gift has been passed on to you. So, Lyria... what do you wish for?”

Lyria looked from Maroku to Hope. Hope’s eyes were warm and full of trust.

Then Lyria took a deep breath and said,

“I wish every kid had a roof over their head like homes.”

Hope’s smile grew bright, and her whole body began to glow with golden light.

90 Years Later

Lyria woke to the sighing of the heat pump, puffing a stream of cold air across her room. She sat up in bed and pushed aside the heavy curtains.

Outside, Roanina unfolded like a restless dream—silver towers catching the early light, tram lines gliding in the air, old brick streets stitched between them like threads on a patchwork cloak.

Before she could smile at it, she heard it:
Shouting. Again.

Her neighbors' voices crashed against the thin walls, tearing the fragile morning quiet. Lyria closed her eyes, her jaw tightening.

"So much for peace," she muttered.

She dressed in her everyday clothes—the queen of the city, in a simple shirt and worn trousers—and padded into her small kitchen. Little cleaning sprites, called shirks, flickered about the counters like pale-blue fireflies, sweeping crumbs into their tiny mouths.

"Good morning," she told them absently.

Lyria took a small tin from the shelf and shook a pinch of shimmering powder into her mug. It sparkled like ground starlight as she carried it to the sink and filled the cup with water, watching it swirl and settle.

When she opened her front door, a man on a rumbling four-wheeled bike zoomed past. He tossed a bundle of mail toward her with the grace of a circus juggler.

"Morning, Lyria!" he called.

She caught the letters against her chest and smiled. "Morning!"

Back at the kitchen island, she split the seal on the first envelope. Numbers and warnings spilled out: the Health Sector begging for more funding, a report on carbon dioxide thickening the air, and how much power the city still needed to feed its growing lights.

Before she could read another line, there came a sharp knock at the door.

Lyria turned, expecting another envelope, but when she opened it, Maroku stood there, grinning as if the whole world were his joke.

"Today is the day," he announced, sweeping into her home without waiting to be invited. "The day Hope returns."

Lyria took a slow sip from her mug. The shimmering drink cooled her tongue.

“Yeah, I know,” she said softly. “The last ten years have just flown by.”

She set her mug down and walked back into the kitchen. “Do you want anything to eat?”

Maroku brushed imaginary dust from his jacket. His eyes glinted, ancient and young all at once. “No. Do I look any good?”

Lyria rolled her eyes and took a bowl from the cupboard, setting it on the counter. “Maroku, you always look good.”

He gave a short, disbelieving laugh and sank onto a stool. “You’re just saying that.”

She pulled out a box of cereal and began to pour. The grain rattled into the bowl like tiny stones.

“So,” Maroku asked, folding his arms on the counter, “do you know what your new wish is going to be?”

Lyria froze, the stream of cereal thinning, then stopping. She stared into the bowl as if the answer might float there.

“No,” she said at last. “Not yet.”

She tucked the cereal box away, crossed to the fridge, and took out the milk. As she poured, Maroku spoke again, his voice lighter than the weight of his words.

“You could wish that no one ever got sick,” he suggested. “That would fix half your problems.”

“Maybe,” Lyria murmured. “I don’t know.”

She set the milk down and stared at its white surface.

“I didn’t see the consequences of my last wish,” she admitted. “Every kid had a home—but some of those homes are full of shouting and fear. And people without homes just band together and have a child so they can get a roof over their heads. It twisted things. It twisted them.”

Maroku nodded, his eternal face briefly somber. “Yes. It disturbed the city’s flow. The pipes, the power, the planning—Roanina itself is limping.”

Lyria lifted her spoon but paused, looking at him instead of her breakfast.

“Thanks for reminding me,” she said. “I was just ten when I made that wish.”

Before he could answer, a terrible sound split the air.

CRASH.

It was the screaming metal sound the whole city feared—steel against steel, something gone terribly wrong.

Lyria and Maroku stared at each other. Her spoon slipped from her fingers and clattered into the bowl, milk splashing like startled tears.

They ran.

Out the door, down the stair, out into the vibrating street—

A car and a tram had collided, their bodies torn open like crushed toys. People lay scattered across the road, groaning, crying, stunned. Shards of glass glittered on the ground like a false snowfall. Pieces of machines smoked and hissed.

Maroku's gaze was pulled upward, past the chaos, to the shadow of the Mountain. There, at its peak, a light had begun to burn—white and steady, like an eye opening.

Hope.

He turned back to Lyria, his voice urgent. "You need to go to Hope."

But Lyria saw only the people before her—the wounded, the frightened, the broken shapes on the road.

"They need help," she said. Then, to Maroku: "You go and distract her. I'll be there soon."

Maroku saw the unshakable resolve in her eyes. For all his age, for all his eternity, he knew better than to argue with that. He nodded once and sprinted toward the Mountain, his figure soon swallowed by the trembling streets.

Lyria knelt beside the nearest person, helping them to their feet, murmuring soft words. Around them, cars were piling up, horns blaring like angry geese caught in a narrow lane.

She stood, anger flaring. She marched to the nearest car and pounded on the hood.

"What is wrong with you?" she shouted. "Can't you see people are hurt?"

The door flew open. A man scrambled out, eyes wild.

"I have to get to the power station," he gasped. "Now."

"Mate, we all have places we need to be," Lyria snapped.

He shook his head furiously. "No—you don't understand. I need to shut down the system controls before the turbines destabilize. If they do, the blast will be a danger bigger than people's homes. Bigger than this."

His phone lit up in his hand: “Boss Calling”.

Lyria smirked, folding her arms. “Oh, you think you’re clever. I’m the queen of this city. If something that serious were happening, I would know.”

Just then, her own phone buzzed in her pocket.

The name on the screen made her spine go cold.

She lifted it to her ear. As the voice on the other end spoke, the color drained from her face. Her expression shifted—from doubt, to confusion, to a fear she tried not to show.

The turbines. The power station. The danger.

It was all true.

Lyria ended the call with a trembling thumb and looked at the man. His chest rose and fell like a panting dog’s.

“I told you so,” he said quietly.

Her eyes flashed, not at him, but at herself.

“Come with me,” she ordered.

He left his keys in the car without a second thought and ran beside her. Together they darted down a side street, racing not toward the Mountain, but away from it—in the opposite direction of Hope’s distant light.

As Lyria and the stranger raced through the narrow side street, their footsteps echoing off old brick and shining glass, Lyria called over her shoulder, “So, what’s your name?”

The man glanced at her with a quick, crooked smile. “Briaric. And you?”

“Lyria,” she replied.

At that, Briaric skidded to a stop. Lyria, surprised, halted beside him. He stared at her as if he’d just stumbled into a legend.

“Lyria...” he murmured. “I feel like I know that name.”

She smiled, a little wry, a little tired. “Well, you don’t trust me yet, clearly.”

Briaric scratched the back of his head, looking both embarrassed and worried. “Okay, listen. We can run out of the city, but the power plant is at least twenty minutes away by car. And we have maybe thirty minutes before everything goes wrong. If we don’t shut it down in time...”

Lyria frowned. "Then why don't you just call someone at the plant and tell them what to do?"

Briaric gave a humorless chuckle and lifted a small metal key that hung around his neck, catching the dim city light.

"Because," he said, "some genius made a law that the plant can only be shut down with five keys. One for each of the main engineers. And I'm the closest one to the station."

Lyria eyed the key thoughtfully. "Wasn't the point of that law to make sure there would always be someone on site with the skill to shut the plant down?"

Briaric tucked the key back beneath his shirt and nodded grimly. "That was the goal. But when people get sick, or crash their cars, or just don't show up... the goal falls apart."

Lyria looked around the maze of side streets, the crooked lines of balconies and wires. Then, suddenly, she smiled.

"Follow me," she said.

They sprinted down an alley, weaving between trash chutes and flickering wall-lamps, until they burst out onto a broader street. A man was just climbing into his car.

"Aldric!" Lyria called. "I need your car."

Aldric stepped out and closed the door again, frowning in confusion. "Why don't you tell me where you need to go, and I'll take you?"

Before Lyria could answer, Briaric emerged from the alley, breathless and impatient. He strode straight up to Aldric.

"Sorry," Briaric said. "We don't have time for polite."

He plucked the keys from Aldric's hand, slid into the driver's seat, and started the engine. Lyria dove into the passenger seat on the other side.

The car leapt forward, the city streaming past in a blur of stone and steel.

"So," Briaric shouted over the roar of the engine, "what do you do for a living, anyway?"

Lyria watched the city whirl by—towering buildings, tangled tram lines, a small child crying on the footpath as someone tried to comfort them.

"It's... complicated," she said.

Briaric huffed a laugh. "Everything is complicated. But I like to think I'm pretty smart. Try me."

Lyria's eyes lingered on the crying child as they sped past.

"I'm someone who makes choices," she said slowly, "that push our society in certain directions."

Briaric turned the wheel, guiding them onto the outer road that led toward the power plant. His mouth curled into a knowing smile.

"That's a fancy way of putting it," he said.

Lyria looked at him sharply. "So you have known who I am this whole time."

"Of course," Briaric admitted cheerfully. "I just wanted to see how you'd describe it."

Lyria gave him a playful shove on the shoulder. "Wow. You're insufferable."

He laughed. "Hey, don't hit the man who's trying to save your city!"

They both fell quiet for a moment, the car eating up the road between Roanina and the looming shapes of towers on the horizon.

Then Briaric asked, more softly, "So... what is your next wish going to be, Queen Lyria?"

She looked out through the windshield, where the world shimmered in the faint haze of power lines and distant turbines.

"I don't know," she whispered. "But I know I have to make it soon."

"Then look around you," Briaric said. "Look at the people. See what they need. See what they want. That's where your answer is hiding."

Lyria studied his face, the seriousness in his eyes.

"What would your wish be," she asked, "if you were the one allowed to make it?"

Briaric's smile dimmed into something gentler, sadder.

"I'm not going to tell you," he said. "You're the one with the pure heart. I'm smart enough to know that if I tell you my wish and you make it, some part of you will always wonder if you did it just because I asked."

He turned his gaze back to the road.

"So if I'm ever going to get what I want," he went on, "all I can hope for is that you see the world the way I see it. And what I see is people—people broken, people trapped in families that don't love them. Children growing up to hate their parents. People who can survive, but not dream."

The car began to slow as the grey bulk of the power plant rose ahead of them, its turbines turning like giant, restless gears in the sky.

“More and more,” Briaric said quietly, “I see my people walking around with empty eyes, like the life has been sucked out of them. So somehow, Queen Lyria, should be to help people dare to dream again. Dare to be happy, dare to fall in love with the little things in life again.”

The car rolled to a stop near the plant’s entrance.

Lyria turned to look at him, but he was already opening his door. He stepped out, then leaned down to hand her the keys through the open window.

“Until next time, Your Majesty,” he said with a crooked grin.

Lyria watched him start to run toward the power plant gates. On a sudden impulse, she cranked the window down farther.

“Briaric!” she called.

He stopped and turned, his breath puffing in pale clouds.

“Are you single?” Lyria asked, half teasing, half serious.

Briaric blinked, then laughed—a bright, startled sound.

“Yes,” he answered. “Why?”

Lyria’s heart beat a little faster. “Do you... want to go out on a date?”

Briaric’s grin spread across his face like sunrise.

“Tomorrow,” he called back. “At Aqmore Eterna. Eight o’clock.”

Lyria smiled, a real smile this time, one that reached all the way to her tired eyes.

“See you there,” she said.

He gave a small bow, then turned and ran through the gates of the power plant, vanishing into its steel and smoke and danger.

Lyria slid across into the driver’s seat, her fingers tightening around the keys. She started the car and turned it back toward the city, toward the distant, waiting Mountain where Hope’s light was growing brighter.

As she drove, she looked out at Roanina—the crowded streets, the leaning houses, the sky-rails and tangled wires. On the sidewalks, people walked with their heads down, faces drawn and gray.

Lyria pulled the car to the side of the road where the Mountain's shadow began, turned off the engine, and stepped out. The air there was thinner, sharper, scented with stone and distant snow.

She began to climb.

With every step, the path grew steeper, and it felt as though unseen hands were laying heavier and heavier weights across her shoulders. Her legs burned, her lungs ached, but still she climbed, following the narrow trail that wound upward like a question.

At last, she reached the peak.

There, at the very top of the world, where the sky bent close to listen, sat Hope—not a flame or a star, but a woman. Her dress was woven from petals and leaves, flowers blooming and fading in soft, endless patterns along the hem. Beside her sat Maroku, his ageless face turned toward the sinking sun. They sat together in silence, watching the golden light pour over Roanina far below.

Lyria stumbled forward and dropped to her knees, chest heaving as she tried to catch her breath.

Hope turned to her, her eyes bright as dawn. "Are you all right?" she asked gently.

Lyria lifted her head and managed a breathless smile. "Yes," she panted. "I'm... great."

Maroku looked over as well, his gaze searching her face. "You look different," he said softly.

Lyria pushed herself to her feet, the wind tugging at her hair. There was a new light in her eyes, fierce and certain.

"I know my wish," she said. "I know what will fix Roanina. What will fix everything."

Hope rose too, watching Lyria as she began to pace slowly around the mountaintop, looking out over the city. The sky-rails glowed faintly, the towers catching the last of the light as day slid into evening.

"So," Hope asked, "what is your wish?"

Lyria turned, her face glowing with hope of her own.

"I wish," she said, "that everyone is happy. All the time."

Hope's smile faded. She glanced at Maroku, then back at Lyria, her eyes now full of sorrow.

"I'm afraid," Hope said softly, "that I cannot grant that wish."

Lyria blinked, taken aback. "Why not?"

Hope stepped closer and laid a warm hand on Lyria's shoulder.

"Because happiness is a moving target," she said. "You can only know joy if you have known sorrow. If I gave your wish as you asked, everyone in Roanina would stop feeling anything at all. No sadness—but no true happiness either. Only... emptiness."

Lyria looked down at her hands, fingers curling in on themselves.

"Then what," she whispered, "could possibly make everyone dream again?"

Maroku stood, brushing mountain dust from his clothes.

"Before you speak another wish," he said, "think it all the way through. Follow it to its end."

Lyria closed her eyes. The wind tugged at her sleeves as if urging her to remember.

"The city is growing," she murmured. "But its people are not happy. The children have houses but not always love. They have food, but not always laughter. It's as if everyone has forgotten how to have fun, how to... wonder."

She opened her eyes and looked straight at Hope.

"I wish," Lyria said, "that we had the kind of magic—technology, if you like—that lets people experience other worlds like our own. New places to explore, new stories to live inside, so their hearts can remember how to dream."

For a moment, Hope simply gazed at her. Then her lips curved into a radiant smile.

"So be it," she whispered.

Her flowered dress rustled like wings. Then, before Lyria's eyes, Hope changed. Her body shimmered and lengthened, petals turning to feathers of flaming gold and ruby red. She became a Fenghuang, a great phoenix-like bird of legend, with a tail that trailed starlight and petals as she rose into the air.

With a cry like a silver bell, Hope launched herself from the peak and flew over Roanina. From her wings, bright feathers fell, drifting down into the city.

Where each feather landed, it blossomed into a glass-like chamber—transparent rooms and domes on rooftops and in courtyards. Inside them, lights shimmered and skies shifted, opening gates to countless other worlds: forests that glowed with blue leaves, oceans in the clouds, cities of singing stone.

Maroku watched this transformation with raised brows, then glanced at Lyria.

"It's going to be interesting," he said, "to see how this turns out."

Lyria smiled, her heart swelling with cautious excitement. "It's going to be a wonderful next ten years," she said.

But before the last word had fully left her lips, a dark smear appeared on the horizon.

From the direction of the power station—a place of steel and humming turbines—black smoke began to rise, curling into the sky like a cruel question mark.

Then, a heartbeat later, came the explosion.

The sound rolled across the city and up the Mountain, a terrible roar that shattered the quiet of the peak. Lyria stared in horror as a blossom of fire flared where she had left Briaric behind.

Her knees gave way, and she dropped to the ground, hands flying to her face.

"No..." she whispered. "No, no, no..."

Maroku turned toward her, the playful light gone from his eyes, replaced by worry.

"I'll deal with this one," he said softly. "Stay here."

Without waiting for an answer, he began to run down the mountain path, swift and sure-footed, racing toward the wounded city below.

Lyria's tears fell freely now, pattering onto the stone at her knees.

"If only it had happened a few seconds earlier," she choked. "I could have wished it away. I could have wished it never happened. I could have brought them all back..."

The wind caught her words and carried them down over Roanina, where new dreams were just beginning to bloom—and old losses, sharp and deep, still had to be faced.

Lyria glanced down at the little silver watch on her wrist. Its hands pointed neatly to 8:00.

When she lifted her eyes, the sign above the doorway glowed softly in the evening light: "Aqmore Eterna."

The restaurant looked almost enchanted, its windows warm with golden lamplight, laughter and music drifting out like a spell.

Lyria stood there for a moment, her heart fluttering like a caged bird, then stepped inside.

She chose a small table by the window, where she could see the door and the street beyond. When the server came, she ordered a simple drink, her fingers wrapped tightly around the menu even after it was taken away.

Time slipped by like sand through an hourglass.

All day she sat there, watching people come and go—friends meeting with bright smiles, families sharing meals, strangers passing in and out like characters in someone else's story. Every time the door opened, Lyria's head lifted, hope sparking in her chest, searching for a familiar face with quick, clever eyes.

But Briaric did not come.

Still, she stayed, long after her drink had gone cold, keeping her silent vigil at Aqmore Eterna. For in her heart, like a small, stubborn lantern, she held one quiet wish:

That somewhere, somehow, in this life or the next, she would see Briaric again.

100 Years Later

Lyria and Maroku sat side by side on a cold stone bench, high above Roanina, watching the first light of dawn spill over the city. The sky was painted in soft pinks and golds, as if the world were trying to start again, gentler this time.

Maroku broke the silence first.

“Lyria,” he asked quietly, “do you know your wish?”

Lyria did not answer at once. She kept her eyes on the rising sun, the light catching in the tears she refused to let fall. At last, she turned to him.

“Yes,” she said. “And you already know what it is.”

Maroku studied her face, his ageless eyes narrowing with worry. “You can’t be serious,” he whispered.

Lyria rose to her feet, the hem of her cloak brushing the stone. She looked down at him with a fierce, trembling resolve.

“You will tell me it will destroy Roanina,” she said. “And you’re right. This wish will tear down everything that’s been built in just a few seconds.”

She turned toward the city, then looked back at him, her expression hard as carved stone.

“I don’t care,” she said. “The power plants are dangerous. People have died making energy.”

Maroku stood now as well, facing her. “Everything is dangerous,” he replied. “We step outside, we might be struck by a carriage or a car. A child can fall into a puddle and drown. We don’t stop living because something is dangerous, or because it frightens us, or because we’re sad. We find what’s broken, and we make a path to mend it.”

Lyria’s eyes filled at last, tears shimmering on her lashes.

“I can’t do this anymore,” she choked. “My first wish brought more pain than it healed. My last wish stole youth from future work and craft. And now...”

She pressed a hand to her chest as if her heart hurt to touch.

“And now I want revenge for Briaric.”

At that moment, the sky above them darkened and then burst into color as Hope descended from the clouds, still in her Fenghuang form, feathers blazing like dawnfire. She swept down in a graceful arc and landed before them. As her talons touched stone, she changed—wings folding into arms, feathers flowing into a dress split in two: one side scattered with black raindrops, the other blooming with flowers.

Hope looked at Lyria, seeing the grief that rimmed her eyes like a storm.

“Are you all right?” she asked gently.

Lyria did not answer at once. Her gaze drifted out over Roanina—over its towers and rails and crowded homes, over the distant scar where the power plant had been.

“Power plants are destroying the world,” she said at last. “They scar the land, sour the air... and one of them killed Briaric. Because of that, I can’t change how I feel about them.”

Maroku stepped closer. “You can’t just erase them,” he said. “We’re working on new ways to make energy, but they’re not ready yet. Not now.”

“It doesn’t matter anymore,” Lyria whispered.

Hope took a careful step toward her, the flowered side of her dress stirring in the wind.

“What you feel now is grief,” Hope said softly. “Grief that is trying to swallow a dream. A hope. You wished for more time with Briaric, but you knew him for less than a day.”

“You don’t understand,” Lyria said, turning on her, eyes shining. “With him, the world made sense. Talking to him was the easiest thing I’ve ever done. Just looking at him made me smile. And the more I learn about him—his family, his friends—the more I feel the weight of losing him.”

Hope’s gaze softened. She glanced at Maroku, and a faint smile touched her lips, as if she were handing the next words to him.

Maroku rested a hand gently on Lyria’s shoulder.

“This isn’t what he would have wanted,” he said. “He wanted *innovation* in the power sector, remember? He dreamed of energy drawn from the wind—kites in the sky catching the currents—or from the sun itself. Ways to give light without burning the world.”

Lyria shook her head wildly. “How would you know?” she demanded. “You never even met him.”

Maroku’s eyes crinkled just a little. “Of course I did,” he said. “When he was promoted. He was a good man.”

He reached into his coat and unfolded a small photograph of Briaric—smiling, alive, unaware of how short his story would be.

Lyria looked at the picture for a long moment, then drew in a deep, shaking breath.

“Sorry,” she whispered, her voice barely more than wind. “But I have to.”

She lifted her head, eyes shining with a terrible, final resolve, and faced Hope.

“I wish,” Lyria said, “that all machines that make power in Roanina be shut down.”

110 Years Later

Maroku ran up the stone steps that wound around the Mountain, his breath sharp in his chest. Behind him thundered men with swords, their boots scraping the rock, their armor clattering like distant thunder. Arrows whistled past his ears—one struck the ground just in front of him, quivering in the stone.

He skidded to a halt and spun around, meeting the charging men head-on. As another arrow flew, Maroku seized one of his attackers and pulled him into its path; the arrow struck the man's chest, and while the others stumbled in shock, Maroku darted beneath the next volley and fled upward.

At last he burst onto the peak of the Mountain.

The sky above him cracked open with radiant color as Hope descended, a blazing Fenghuang with wings of gold and ember-red. She swept down in a spiral of light, landing on the summit just as Maroku stumbled forward, exhausted.

In that same instant, the sword-bearing men reached the top. They rushed him from behind, blades raised, ready to strike.

Hope turned, her feathers rippling, and saw the danger. In a heartbeat she shifted into her human form—her dress divided: one half dripping with embroidered black raindrops, the other blooming with flowers. She tore a handful of dark teardrops from the black side and flung them at the men.

The teardrops turned to shadow midair, wrapping around the attackers like strands of night. One by one, they crumpled to the ground and lay still, their threat ended as gently as a story closing.

Hope stepped toward Maroku, her eyes filled with concern. "What happened?" she asked.

Maroku let out a breathless, humorless laugh as he sank onto a nearby rock.

"You granted Lyris's wish," he said. "All the power machines shut down. And when you turn off everything that runs on power, well... chaos was inevitable."

Hope's gaze drifted past him, searching the sky, the path, the world below. "Where is Lyris?" she asked quietly.

Maroku looked up at her, the eternal shadows in his eyes deepened by something like grief.

"If you're looking for Lyris," he said, "you can stop."

Hope frowned. "Why?"

"She was killed years ago," Maroku replied.

Hope's eyes narrowed, studying his face, his voice, his heartbeat beneath the words. She found no lie there.

"It happened about two years into this decade," he went on softly. "It was her own wish that set it all in motion. It destroyed everything in a single second."

Silence settled over the peak like a heavy cloak. Hope turned toward Roanina, spread out below them—a patchwork of broken lights and quiet streets. Her heart, woven of both flowers and storms, ached.

"I must find another pure heart," she whispered.

Before Maroku could answer, Hope stepped back, spreading her arms. Feathers burst from her shoulders, and once again she became the Fenghuang, wings unfurling in a blaze of gold and scarlet. With a powerful sweep, she launched herself from the Mountain and flew over the city.

She glided above roofs and alleys, markets and ruins, searching.

At last, in a small, crumbling courtyard, she saw a little girl sitting alone beside a cracked fountain, tracing patterns in the dust with a stick and humming to herself. Light clung to the child like a promise.

Hope swooped down behind a low wall and shifted back into her human form. She stepped forward, her dress rustling, half-storm and half-garden.

"Hello, little one," Hope said gently.

The girl turned, eyes wide. "Hello... Wait, where did *you* come from?"

Hope smiled. "I came from the bird you just saw in the sky. She and I are the same."

The girl's face blossomed into wonder. "Are you... Hope?" she breathed, almost afraid to say the name too loudly.

"Yes," Hope answered, her smile deepening as she saw the joy on the girl's face. "If you know my legend, then you know what I must ask next."

The little girl sat up straighter, her whole face shining.

"You're going to ask for my wish," she said. "And my wish is... I wish to undo the last wish."

Hope's eyes sparkled like stars reflected in water. She nodded once.

"So be it."

Her body dissolved into a storm of shimmering light—petals, raindrops, and feathers all at once—spreading out over Roanina. The magic swept through the city like a soft wind turning

pages backward, reaching toward the moment of the last wish, ready to rewrite the story once more.

120 Years Later

Hope, in her radiant Fenghuang form, glided down from the sky and landed upon the familiar peak of the Mountain. The wind quieted around her, as if the whole world were holding its breath.

She looked up—and paused.

There, waiting for her on the stone summit, stood the little girl she had once met in the city... only she was not so little anymore. Time had stretched her into a young maiden, her eyes still bright, her smile still warm. Beside her stood Maroku, and for the first time in many years, there were two matching smiles on that mountain.

Hope's golden feathers folded inward as she changed shape, becoming a young woman whose face and form echoed the girl's own—like an older sister shaped from the same dream. Her dress shimmered, half flowers, half soft rain.

"So," Hope asked gently, "what do you want your wish to be, then?"

The girl turned, looking first at Hope, then at Maroku. The wind tugged at her hair, but her voice was steady.

"I wish," she said, "that Maroku had a pure heart."

Hope's lips curved into a tender smile. "That is a very kind wish."

Maroku's eyes widened. He took a step back, shaking his head. "You don't have to do this," he told her. His voice was rough, as if it had forgotten how to speak tenderness.

But the girl only smiled wider.

"You've seen this city," she said to him, "when it shone brighter than anywhere else. And you've seen it on its darkest days. If anyone should help guide its future, it should be you."

Hope turned her gaze to Maroku. In that moment, the world seemed to grow very still—the clouds paused, the wind hushed, even the distant city seemed to lean in and listen.

Deep within Maroku's chest, something long asleep began to stir.

The shadows wrapped around his heart loosened, then fell away like old, cracked bark from a living tree. Beneath them, a soft, steady light emerged—a heart clear and bright and pure once more, as it had been in the days before envy and fear had tangled it.

Maroku drew in a trembling breath, pressing a hand to his chest as if surprised to feel it beat so freely.

Hope smiled at the girl, then at him.

And above the city of Roanina, the dawn seemed to grow just a little brighter.

The Beginning Of An Old Time

130 Years Later

Hope soared toward the mountain peak in her true form, the Fenghuang, feathers blazing like sunrise. At the top, she saw Maroku standing there, his heart shining pure again.

She folded her wings and landed softly on the stone. In a swirl of light, she changed into a woman, her dress a simple farm-girl style covered in tiny flowers that moved gently in the wind.

Hope smiled at him.

"You look happy," she said. "Happier than I've seen you in a long time."

Maroku walked over, took her hand, and spun her playfully in a little circle.

"I am," he laughed. "Because now I can build the future this city needs—the city we deserve. And I know the perfect wish to start it with."

Hope twirled away from him and looked up into his eyes.

"What's the wish?" she asked.

Maroku's smile grew warm and steady.

"I wish," he said, "that no one in this city can ever be trapped or badly injured again and get stick ever again."

Hope's eyes shone.

"That's a beautiful wish," she said. "Let's make it real."

She began to glow, soft golden light spilling from her hands and drifting down toward the city below. The magic wrapped itself around streets, homes, and towers, weaving quiet protection into every corner.

When the wish was done, Hope and Maroku stayed on the mountain together. They spent the rest of the day dancing on the peak, hand in hand, watching the sun rise, arc across the sky, and finally fall—while a safer, kinder future began to bloom beneath them.

140 Years Later

Hope waited on the mountain peak, the wind playing with her hair. Far below, the futuristic city shone with gentle lights and moving trains, full of life and motion.

Footsteps sounded on the stone steps.

Maroku appeared at the top, his pure heart glowing quietly inside him. He looked at Hope and smiled.

"I think everyone is happy," he said. "You did it. I think we've finally brought joy to everyone."

Hope walked to the edge and looked down at the bright city. The streets were busy but calm. Lights glowed in windows. Machines hummed without smoke. Everything looked... peaceful.

Maroku stood beside her and explained, "Everyone works about forty hours a week now. There are still homeless people, but we have homes ready for them. We have people out looking, making plans to help them, to bring them into the workforce, to give them places to live."

Hope turned and smiled at him.

"I think you did it."

Maroku pointed toward a cluster of shining towers.

"If you look over there, you'll see a new kind of power plant," he said. "It doesn't send smoke into the air. We're slowly changing from old power to new power."

Hope watched his face. There was real joy there—deep, honest, hard-earned joy.

"Just like that," she said softly, "you did it."

Maroku chuckled. "You don't spend enough time with humans," he told her. "They're happy now. But like everything, this happiness won't last forever."

Hope took his hand and began to sway it from side to side, drawing him into a little dance on the mountaintop.

"Then let's enjoy it while it lasts," she said, laughing.

They danced in each other's arms, turning slowly, the sunlight warm on their backs, the wind wrapping around them like music.

Then—

A sound cut through the air: the whisper of something flying fast.

Hope heard it a heartbeat too late.

She looked up just in time to see an arrow buried in Maroku's chest.

He stumbled and fell.

"Maroku!" Hope dropped with him, her hands catching his shoulders. "No, no, no..."

She rolled him gently and pulled the arrow out. His blood stained her hands.

"It's okay," Maroku rasped, trying to smile. "I'm Eternal. It will heal."

Hope watched the wound... but it didn't close. The skin stayed torn. The blood did not stop.

Panic tightened in her chest.

"Wish for it to heal," she begged. She pressed her glowing hands against his chest. "It's not healing on its own. Wish for it to heal!"

Maroku looked at her with soft, tired eyes.

"Maybe... it's time," he whispered.

Hope shook her head, tears already gathering.

"No, it's not. Wish for it to heal!"

Maroku held her gaze, then smiled faintly.

"I wish," he said, "that you will find peace one day."

Magic sparked beneath Hope's hands, answering the wish—his wish, not hers.

Her eyes burned with anger and grief.

"What are you doing?" she cried. "You are my peace. You're the light in my darkness!"

She glanced at the arrow on the ground and saw a faint, dark coating along the tip.

Poison.

The poison was already moving through his body, carried by his Eternal heart.

Maroku lifted a shaking hand and touched the center of her chest.

"Peace is found in here," he said softly.

Then he raised his fingers to her forehead.

"And not in here."

He smiled, even as his strength faded.

"I think," he whispered, "I've finally found what I was the Eternal of."

Tears poured down Hope's face.

"What was it?" she asked, voice breaking.

Maroku's eyes shone.

"Faith," he said, "and mistrust."

Hope frowned through her tears. "Why those?"

"Because I had faith you would always come back to me," he replied, "and I knew some people would always mistrust me."

His eyes slowly closed. His body went limp in her arms.

Hope stared around her, vision blurred by tears. On a distant rooftop, she saw a figure with a bow, lowering it.

Her grief ignited into fury.

In a burst of flame, she turned into the Fenghuang and shot toward the building, faster than the wind. Just before she reached the archer, she changed back into a woman—this time in her skin-tight black outfit, horns curling from her shoulders and head, her presence sharp and terrifying.

She seized the man by the throat.

"Why?" she roared.

The man smiled bitterly despite her grip.

"His wish," he said. "I wished no one would get sick. That meant the people who were already sick stayed sick. And because no one else was getting sick anymore, all the innovation, all the research that might have cured them... stopped. My mother could have been cured one day—but not in his perfect world."

Hope's eyes grew dark. Her irises turned pitch black, and black tears began to spill down her cheeks.

"I will take all your hope from you," she said coldly. "I will leave you only despair."

More men burst through the doorway behind him, weapons in hand.

Hope let go of the archer and raised her hands. Black teardrops flew from her fingers, hardening into daggers in midair. They struck the men, one after another, and they fell.

She walked through the building like a storm of shadows, hurling those dagger-tears, driven by rage and grief, cutting down everyone in her path.

Then, in a flash of light and wings, another figure appeared before her.

Love.

She stood in her Erinyes form—powerful, fierce, and radiant—blocking Hope's way.

"Stop," Love said firmly, stepping toward her.

Hope looked down at herself and saw her own shape twisting, her form shifting into her Wraith form—dark, hollow, and full of sorrow.

"You let your love turn into hate," Love said. "Don't let it turn your Hope into despair."

Hope's anger wavered. She turned to look at Love—and in that moment, her shape shrank and softened. She became a little girl again, sobbing, her dress damp with black tears.

Love's Erinyes form faded. She became an older woman with kind eyes, wearing a dress covered in soft, glowing hearts.

She stepped forward and wrapped her arms around her sister.

Hope—now a small girl in pants and a shirt covered in black tear patterns—buried her face in Love's shoulder and cried as Love held her, two sisters standing together in the ruins of a city, trying to keep Hope from turning completely into despair.

The End Of An Era

Ten years passed.

In all that time, Hope never once showed her face on the mountain peak again. The stone path grew quiet, and the wind was the only one who remembered her steps.

But the people of the city still spoke of her.

Sometimes, they said, on dark or lonely nights, a great Fenghuang could be seen flying high above the rooftops—her feathers glowing softly, her eyes full of tears. She would circle the city once or twice, crying quietly, and then she would fly away before anyone could call her name.

The city was called Roanina.

No map could show the way to Roanina. To find it, a person needed more than directions—they needed faith.

They had to believe in the idea of a hidden city: a place that could protect people from disasters, a place where food would never run out. They had to have faith in the people around them, faith that they could build something better together.

And most of all, they had to have faith that one day, Hope would return to them all.

They believed she would come back and show them the path to the next life, and even beyond that—guiding them through darkness into something brighter.

Long ago, Hope and Dream had made a bargain. It began as a small, pitying deal... but underneath it was something stronger: a faith that human beings could grow, and change, and become more than they once were.